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‘We’re either going to be a leader for what to do or what not to do.’

KEVIN CHU, *executive director of the Vermont Futures Project*

Struggling UVM sees sports as a way out

With luring students the name of the game, amenities pitched as key

By Diti Kohli

GLOBE STAFF

In May, the president of the University of Vermont, Marlene Tromp, asked state lawmakers for \$12 million for the school’s athletics and recreational renovations.

The money, she pleaded, was about much more than sports.

Aging locker rooms, uncomfortable arena seats, and a dearth of treadmills are “impacting students’ willingness to come to UVM,” Tromp said. “We need those students for

the future of this state.”

The request encapsulates UVM’s strategy to withstand the forces hammering higher education: schools are closing, federal support is going away, and the shrinking population of college-aged young adults is leaving all but the most elite schools fiercely competing for students. This “demographic cliff” is a five-alarm bell higher education insiders have been ringing for decades, and UVM, the flagship school of a graying state, is feeling the heat.

It is suffering through a \$12 million budget deficit and expects the incoming class of freshmen students to decline by 15 percent this fall.

At this ominous moment, UVM is betting that athletic amenities, such as a bouldering wall, hydrotherapy pools, and a new basketball court, will help balance the scales.

Tromp ultimately got the state money and says donors have lined up an additional \$51 million. (UVM still needs another \$32 million for the renovations.)

Once completed, the project will transform the school’s athletic complex and create the largest indoor venue in Vermont, a 5,000-seat space for concerts, events, and sports of all levels. There will be more gym space for students, shinier offices for coaches, and a hospitality suite for athletics donors. University officials estimate the improvements would double use of the facilities and serve both students and everyday Vermonters.

Yet more than anything, the project is a not-so-secret admissions

UNIVERSITY, Page A9

Effort to control rents takes a blow

Compromise between sides now unlikely as SJC tosses question over technicality

By Andrew Brinker

GLOBE STAFF

After years of urging the Legislature to rein in the soaring cost of housing in Massachusetts, tenant advocates had finally found momentum earlier this year.

A ballot question they put forward that would have restored rent control for the first time since the 1990s had for the first time in recent memory commandeered the attention of real estate groups and the Legislature — sparking talks that could have led to new tenant protections as soon as this month.

But that progress came to an unceremonious halt Tuesday, when the state’s highest court threw out that ballot question, seizing on a technicality that justices said rendered it unfit to appear before voters.

In the stunning 27-page ruling, Justice Frank Gaziano wrote that the rent control question could not move forward because it would have exempted units in religious facilities. Under the Massachusetts Constitution, certain matters, including religion, cannot be subject to an initiative petition.

“By including an express exemption for facilities operated solely for religious purposes, the petition impermissibly makes religion ‘a factor in [the petition’s] application,’” Gaziano wrote.

RENT CONTROL, Page A8

National gun groups keep eye on Mass. ballot question

By Chris Van Buskirk

GLOBE STAFF

If gun rights activists can make it in Massachusetts, the thinking goes, they may just make it anywhere.

Second Amendment supporters have put a referendum to repeal some of the state’s gun ownership prohibitions before Massachusetts voters this fall that could also serve as a trial balloon of sorts for using the ballot box to peel back restrictive firearms laws.

The ballot initiative is a rarity nationally in this election cycle and comes amid a bevy of gun-related court challenges, including one from opponents of the new Massachusetts restrictions. But many of those legal cases are in a holding pattern, either awaiting rulings from the Supreme Court or still working their way through the judicial system.

Toby Leary, owner of Cape Gun Works in Hyanis and the chair of the campaign to repeal the Massachusetts law, said a successful referendum in one of the country’s bluest corners could “set the stage for other states that have veto referendums like this.”

GUNS, Page A8

GIVING THEM THE SLIP

Tourists from around the world want a shot at the notorious ‘Cop Slide’



PHOTOS BY JOHN TLUMACKI/GLOBE STAFF

The city points out the slide is for kids, but adults have other ideas.

By Spencer Buell

GLOBE STAFF

At all hours of the day, all year long, the tall metal tube calls to them.

Tourists walking the Freedom Trail line up for a chance to launch down its twists and turns.

Boston Marathon runners cross the finish line, then descend it, still wearing their race jackets.

So have hundreds of Scots, here for the World Cup, among them a bagpiper tooting “Scotland the Brave.”

Between the World Cup, the country’s 250th birthday, and the Tall Ships arriving, visitors from around the world are flocking to the city this “Mega Summer.” And many of them say the huge metal slide next to City Hall, made famous by a viral video of a Boston police officer flying out of it upside down, is a top priority.

Boston is a city of landmarks. And at this point, there’s no denying it: The “Cop Slide” has become one of them.

“I must note that this slide is designed for people 12 years and younger. That needs to be stated, liability-wise,” said Mayor Michelle Wu, standing at the foot of the slide last week. “It is also a huge must-do that we know visitors

SLIDE, Page A9

Congress finds common ground on Warren-backed housing bill

By Jim Puzzanghera

GLOBE STAFF

WASHINGTON — The affordability crisis has finally hit home in Congress, prompting an overwhelmingly bipartisan effort to try to bring down high housing costs.

On Tuesday, the House voted 358-32 to approve legislation, championed by Massachusetts Senator Elizabeth Warren, designed to increase the supply of homes and apartments through streamlined regulations, incentives, and innovation. The swift action followed the Senate’s 85-5 approval on Monday, ending months of negotiations between the two chambers.

The bill now goes to the White House, and President Trump is expected to sign it Wednesday.

The 21st Century Road to Housing Act is the first major bipartisan action by

Congress since the 2024 election to address the soaring post-pandemic cost of living that was a major factor in Trump’s return to the White House. Although he’s dismissed the affordability crisis as a politically motivated Democratic “hoax,” passage of the legislation shows a broad consensus on both sides of the political aisle that housing costs need to be addressed before November’s midterms.

“The bill came together because no one wanted to go back home and explain to their constituents why a bill with such deep, broad, bipartisan support couldn’t actually pass,” said David Dworkin, president of the National Housing Conference, a coalition of organizations including banks, homebuilders, realtors, and housing advocacy groups.

Housing costs have become increasingly unaffordable for many Americans:

HOUSING, Page A7

The United States and Iran were in dispute over whether Tehran had agreed to allow UN inspections of its nuclear sites. **A6.**

Two Boston city councilors proposed extending the Orange Line beneath Blue Hill Avenue for what they said would be better service. **B1.**

Jacob Wirth, the storied German beer hall that has sat dark for eight years, could reopen as soon as next year, its owners say. **B5.**

The boom is on again at last for Route 128 semiconductor firms. **B5.**

Luxury steakhouses have become big business in the Boston area. Who’s eating at them, and which one is clearly the best? **G1.**

He’s #1

AJ Dybantsa, the pride of Brockton and a star at Brigham Young, was chosen first by the Washington Wizards in the NBA Draft. He was the third Massachusetts player taken at number one, following Patrick Ewing in 1985 and Jimmy Walker in 1967. **C1.**



Still in drought

Wednesday: Sunny, less humid. High 81-86.

Thursday: More of the same. High 79-84.

High tide: 7:56 a.m., 8:15 p.m.

Sunrise: 5:08 a.m. Sunset: 8:25 p.m.

Weather and Comics, G6-7. Obituaries, C11.

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